Varenna, I found the participants (John Bell included) in hot debates about the first experimental results regarding the Bell inequalities," Zeh recalled later. "I had never heard of them." Nonetheless, Zeh was relieved and gratified to find that Bell and the others valued his work, even if some of them disagreed with his conclusions. Wigner, in his keynote address to the conference, laid out six possible solutions to the measurement problem; he included Zeh's combination of decoherence and many-worlds among them.

But when Zeh returned to Heidelberg, he found his colleagues there as disdainful as ever of his work in quantum foundations—so much so that his career had stalled entirely. "There was a lot of naiveté on my side," Zeh recalled. "I thought when you have a good idea and you publish it, then everybody should read that and accept that, which is of course quite wrong." Zeh soldiered on, trying to look on the bright side. "I concentrated on these issues because I had decided that my career was destroyed," Zeh said. "I would never get a [full] professorship because of these things already, and so I said, 'Now I can just do what I like.'" Zeh's own job was safe as long as he stayed at Heidelberg; he had tenure, though he was denied promotion. "I did not have to suffer," he recalled. "[But]my students never had a chance. I had not expected that." When Zeh's students went looking for academic work, they were denied job after job, since they had not done "real" physics. "This," Zeh said, "was something I will never be ready to forgive." Zeh dubbed these the "dark ages of decoherence." They would not lift for over a decade.

Despite his groundbreaking experiment, John Clauser's career had also stalled out—and unlike Zeh, he didn't have a permanent position. When his postdoctoral position at Berkeley ended, Clauser struggled to find another job. "I was sort of young, naive, and oblivious to all of this," Clauser recalled. "I thought it was interesting physics. I had yet to recognize just how much of a stigma there was, and I just chose to ignore it. I was just having fun." Clauser's PhD advisor, Pat Thaddeus, wrote a "recommendation" letter for Clauser's new job search, in which he warned prospective employers that Clauser's Bell experiments were "junk science."